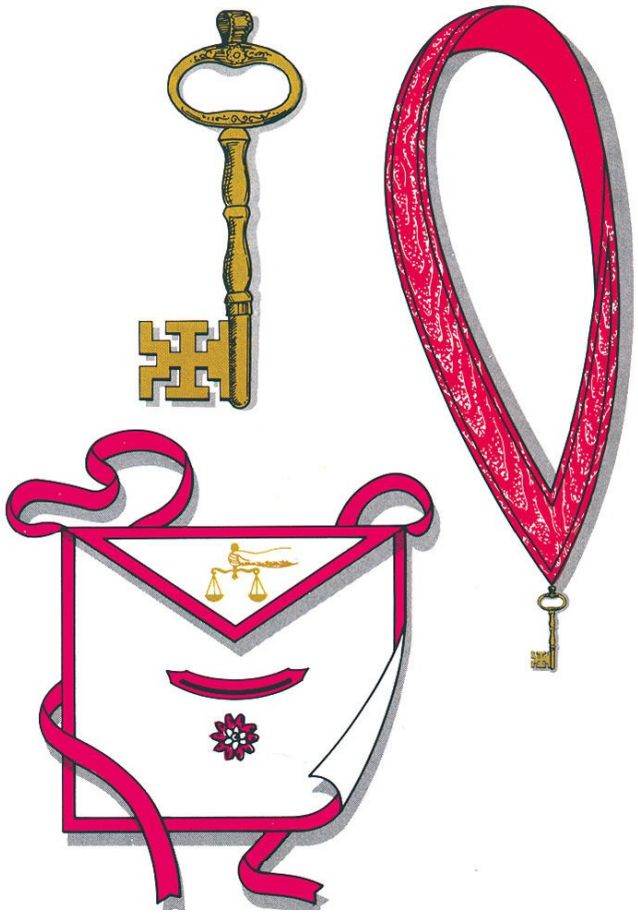
The 7th Degree – Provost and Judge



The apron is of white lambskin, edged in red. In the center is a red–edged pocket, with a red and white rosette just below the opening. This pocket holds the plans for the Temple. On the flap is embroidered a hand of justice holding a scale.

The jewel is a gold key which unlocks the ebony box seen in the ceremony. This ebony box represents the human heart where the candidate is to lock up the secrets of the order and as Albert G. Mackey says, "... in the human heart are deposited the secret designs and motives of our conduct by which we propose to erect the spiritual temple of our lives"[1] ("Ebony Box," in *Encyclopedia of Freemasonry*). This key is especially emblematic of that justice and uprightness that alone can unlock for us the mysteries contained in the higher degrees and enable us to advance toward perfection.

The cordon is a broad, watered crimson ribbon, worn from right to left and

from which is suspended the jewel.

DUTY

Let justice be the guide of all your actions.

LESSONS

All actions have consequences. Be just in judging others' motives.

FOR REFLECTION

Are the duties of a judge a burden or an honor?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Equal balance, ebony box, triangle, the color red.

Originally called Irish Master, this degree was worked in France by Masonic Lodges claiming possession of a charter from Ireland. The members of these Irish Lodges asserted jurisdiction over ordinary lodges and maintained they had the right of inspection. The jewel of the Irish Masters was a key symbolizing this authority. When the Rite of Perfection was formed in the middle of the 18th century, this degree was incorporated as the seventh and its name was changed to Provost and Judge. The ritual was modified by Pike to teach the moral lesson of justice.

CEREMONY

The symbolic color is red and appears in the hangings and apron. Unlike in other degrees where it represents the virtue of zeal, red takes on a special meaning here—to remind us of the violent death of the Master Hiram.

After the death of the Master Hiram, King Solomon appointed seven Provosts and Judges to administer justice among the workmen of the Temple. They were to adjust demands, listen to complaints and settle any disputes, administering the same laws to both Hebrew and Phoenician alike. The Chief Provost and Judge was entrusted with the key to an ebony box which held the records of the tribunal.

In the ceremony Uriah complains to Naboth that Phoenician workers “pollute” the temple by their presence. The two approach Zabud, the Provost and Judge, presenting their sides of the dispute, each seeking his favor on their behalf. This argument has its basis in the covenant established between God and the people of Israel signified by the act of circumcision. This covenant separated the Jews from their neighbors who, for example, were forbidden to share in the Passover feast (Exod. 12:48) unless they were willing to undergo this rite.

Naboth (from the Hebrew meaning “prominence”), explains that he governs the laborers who work on the south wall. Between him and the workmen a difference has arisen because he has hired uncircumcised Phoenician workmen. Naboth expects this difficulty to come before the judges. He requests Zabud to befriend him in the decision for which Naboth suggests he will use his influence with the king to advance Zabud’s position. Zabud dismisses Naboth saying, “As a fellow of the Craft, I have called thee Brother, but as a Judge, you are a stranger.”

Upon Naboth’s exit, Uriah, a general laborer, enters. Uriah explains that the workmen on the south wall wish to remove all those workmen who are uncircumcised. Zabud also dismisses Uriah. He chastises him for attempting to corrupt the judges by asking a judge to assume powers which are not his; that is, to show religious preference by dismissing non–Jews who were in the days of Solomon uncircumcised.

The heavy burden of Provost and Judge forms the basis for the following instruction:

1. The judge must himself be impartial, cautious, merciful and of pure morals.
2. Only a false judge pardons errors in himself and not others.
3. A judge must be aware of the grave responsibility he bears.
4. A judge must inform himself fully of the law he is called upon to enforce.

5. An unjust judge will be smitten by God.
6. Remorse will pursue the corrupt judge beyond the grave.
7. Judge not unless you are willing to stand under the same judgment.

The candidate is invested with the jewel, apron and cordon. He also receives additional instruction on the symbols found in this degree. The triangle suspended over the ebony box represents the Deity as well as justice, equity and impartiality. The equal balance cautions us to weigh carefully those who present themselves for our mysteries. It should be noted that the lodge opens and closes at the same hour to remind us that the Master's station is everywhere and that justice also should be universal.

LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma* the concept of justice is explored from three principle points of view: consequences attend our every action; we should be just in judging other men's motives; and we can only be just when charitable. Masonry does not seek to take the place of religion but, like religion, acknowledges a higher law than that of man.

Justice:

Those who are invested with the power of judgment should judge the causes of all persons uprightly and impartially, without any personal consideration of the power of the mighty, or the bribe of the rich, or the needs of the poor. ... They must divest themselves of prejudice and preconception. They must hear patiently, remember accurately, and weigh carefully the facts... (p. 126).

In our intercourse with others, there are two kinds of injustice: the first, of those who offer an injury; the second, of those who have it in their power to avert an injury from those to whom it is offered, and yet do it not. So active injustice may be done in two ways by force and by fraud, –of which force is lion–like, fraud fox–like both utterly repugnant to social duty, but fraud the more detestable (p. 127).

Every wrong done by one man to another, whether it affect his person, his property, his happiness, or his reputation, is an offense against the law of justice (p. 127).

[Masonry] *teaches this great and momentous truth: that wrong and injustice once done cannot be undone; but are eternal in their consequences; once committed, are numbered with the irrevocable Past; that the wrong that is done contains its own retributive penalty as surely and as naturally as the acorn contains the oak* (p. 127).

Surely, we shall do less wrong and injustice, if the conviction is fixed and embedded in our souls that everything done is done irrevocably, that even the Omnipotence of God cannot uncommit a deed, cannot make that undone which has been done; that every act of ours must bear its allotted fruit, according to the everlasting laws—must remain forever ineffaceably inscribed on the tablets of Universal Nature (p. 128).

We may be able to say—"This man has lied, has pilfered, has forged, ...; and that has gone through life with clean hands." But we cannot say that the former has not struggled long, though unsuccessfully, against temptations under which the second would have succumbed without an effort. We can say which has the cleanest hands before man; but not which has the cleanest soul before God (p. 130).

When we condemn or pity the fallen, how do we know that, tempted like him, we should not have fallen like him, as soon, and perhaps with less resistance? How can we know what we should do if we were out of employment, famine crouching, gaunt, and hungry, on our fireless hearth, and our children wailing for bread? We fall not because we are not enough tempted! (p. 131).

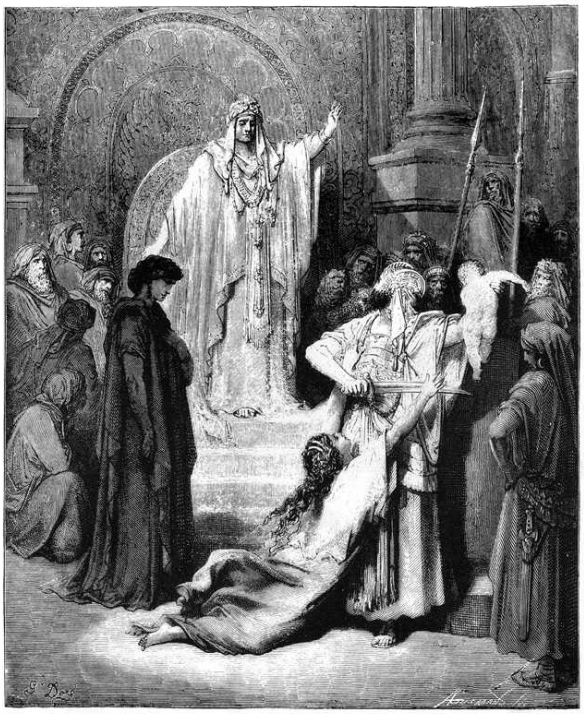
Let each man ask his own heart! Of how many of our best and of our worst acts and qualities are our most intimate associates utterly unconscious! How many virtues does not the world give us credit for, that we do not possess; or vices condemn us for, of which we are not the slaves! It is a small portion of our evil

deeds and thoughts that ever comes to light; and of our few redeeming goodnesses, the largest portion is known to God alone (p. 131).

We are all men of like passions, propensities, and exposures. There are elements in us all, which might have been perverted, through the successive processes of moral deterioration, to the worst of crimes (p. 134).

Speak kindly of your erring brother! God pities him: Christ has died for him: Providence waits for him: Heaven's mercy yearns toward him; and Heaven's spirits are ready to welcome him back with joy. Let your voice be in unison with all those powers that God is using for his recovery! (p. 134).

... let the true Mason never forget the solemn injunction, necessary to be observed at almost every moment of a busy life: "JUDGE NOT, LEST YE YOURSELVES BE JUDGED: FOR WHATSOEVER JUDGMENT YE MEASURE UNTO OTHERS, THE SAME SHALL IN TURN BE MEASURED UNTO YOU" [Matt. 7:1–2] (p. 135).



The Judgment of Solomon
by Gustave Dore

In this elegant portrayal of King Solomon's most famous judgment we see the importance of wisdom.

Two women, rival claimants for the same child, appeal to the king. He suggests cutting the baby in half, giving part to each. The true mother reveals herself by her selfless love, willing to give up the child that it might live (1 Kings 3: 16–28).

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1. Albert G. Mackey, rev. Robert I. Clegg and H. L. Haywood, *Encyclopedia of Freemasonry,* 3 vols. (Richmond, Va.: Macoy Publishing, 1966), s.v. “Ebony Box.”